



Customer journey partitioning: A customer-centric conceptualization beyond stages and touchpoints

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ABSTRACT

Understanding customer experiences through customer journeys has become a managerial priority. The customer experience literature divides customer journeys into stages, but these divisions disregard the customer's perspective. Research has shown that individuals partition extended processes—such as customer journeys—into events, thereby influencing how they subsequently remember their experiences. Therefore, this paper seeks to conceptualize customer journey partitioning and its influence on the remembered experience. Based on the event segmentation and experienced utility literature, we propose that customers partition their journeys when they encounter distinctive changes, and that the interaction of customer journey partitioning and the sequence of lived experiences influences the remembered experience. We then discuss implications for customer journey design and present boundary conditions that provide nuance to these implications. This paper contributes to the customer experience literature by conceptualizing customer journey partitioning, understanding its influence on the remembered experience, and proposing new dimensions for customer journey design.

1. Introduction

Understanding the customer experience is a key priority for business practitioners (Ostrom et al., 2021). Offering positive experiences throughout a customer journey is considered a source of competitive advantage (Kranzbühler et al., 2018). Hence, practitioners propose that organizations should focus not only on touchpoints but on the entire customer journey, potentially leading to positive outcomes, such as higher revenue and reduced churn (Rawson et al., 2013).

Customer experience refers to a customer's responses and reactions throughout a customer journey (Becker & Jaakkola, 2020; Lemon & Verhoef, 2016). The customer journey is a process that extends over time and has traditionally been divided into stages, such as pre-purchase, purchase, and post-purchase (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016). However, research has shown that in processes that extend over time, such as customer journeys, individuals undergo a perceptual and cognitive process in which they partition their ongoing journeys into bounded events (e.g., Newston, 1973; Zacks et al., 2007). Yet, this customer-centric perspective on how the journey is partitioned has not been considered in the customer experience literature, despite calls for research (Bitran et al., 2008; LaTour & Carbone, 2014).

Understanding customer journey partitioning from the customer's perspective is important because it affects how customers remember their experiences (Gold et al., 2017; Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Zacks & Tversky, 2001). The remembered experience, in turn, influences customers' attitudes, evaluations, and behavioral intentions (e.g., Koenig-Lewis & Palmer, 2008; Wirtz et al., 2003). Thus, customer journey partitioning has the potential to indirectly influence these important customer outcomes. By understanding how this process happens, practitioners can use this knowledge in customer journey design, for example, by designing interruptions in the customer journey, and therefore influence the remembered experience and other customer outcomes (e.g., Gold et al., 2017; Wirtz et al., 2003).

Given this background, the purpose of this paper is to conceptualize customer journey partitioning and its influence on the remembered experience. Three research questions (RQs) guide this paper. First, considering that customer journey partitioning refers to a customer's perceptual and cognitive processes, RQ1 asks: How do customers partition their journeys? Second, considering that customer journey partitioning influences customers' memories (e.g., Gold et al., 2017), which in turn determine their attitudes, evaluations, and behavioral intentions (e.g., Wirtz et al., 2003), RQ2 asks: How does customer

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journey partitioning influence the remembered experience? Third, considering that “the design of customer journeys is the new marketing battleground” (Gopaldas & Siebert, 2022, p. 94), RQ3 asks: How can organizations use customer journey partitioning in their journey design to positively influence the remembered experience?

To answer these questions, we adopt a theory adaptation approach in which we integrate two distinct method theories to inform our RQs and extend the conceptual domain of customer experience (Jaakkola, 2020): psychological perspectives on event segmentation (e.g., Newston, 1973; Zacks et al., 2007) and experienced utility (e.g., Kahneman et al., 1993; Redelmeier & Kahneman, 1996). We present our conceptualization through the development of propositions (Uлага et al., 2021).

Our conceptualization contributes to the customer experience literature and practice in several ways. First, it presents a customer-centric proposal of how customers partition customer journeys. Whereas the customer experience literature tends to divide the customer journey into stages from an organization’s perspective (e.g., Lemon & Verhoef, 2016), without considering how customers perceive these divisions (e.g., Becker et al., 2020), we propose that distinctive changes in the customer journey form the basis for customer journey partitioning. Second, our conceptualization proposes that the interaction between the sequences of lived experiences and the perception of event boundaries influences how customers remember their experiences. While previous customer experience studies have considered how peaks, ends, and trends in the customer journey influence the remembered experience (e.g., Zomerdijs & Voss, 2010), this literature has largely ignored the fact that the “peak–end” rule does not apply to extended processes such as customer journeys. By integrating two distinct method theories, we offer a more suitable proposition of how peaks, ends, and trends influence the remembered experience of a customer journey. Third, we add two new dimensions of customer journey design (e.g., Homburg et al., 2017; Kuehn et al., 2019): the design of *distinctive changes* in the customer journey and the design of *stimuli* to trigger an intended sequence of lived experiences. Both dimensions challenge some commonly held assumptions in the customer experience literature. For example, we provide nuance to the assumptions of smooth and seamless journeys as the ideal (e.g., Kuehn et al., 2019) by proposing that interruptions in customer journeys can be desirable depending on when they happen. Finally, by identifying boundary conditions around our conceptualization, we provide tailored recommendations for how organizations can design the customer journey to positively influence the remembered experience.

Section 2 provides an overview of the customer experience literature. Section 3 draws on the psychological perspectives of event segmentation to propose how customers partition their journeys. Section 4 relies on experienced utility to propose how customer journey partitioning influences the remembered experience. Section 5 proposes how organizations can use customer journey partitioning to positively influence the remembered experience and presents boundary conditions, yielding tailored recommendations for organizations. Section 6 concludes the paper.

2. Conceptual background: Customer experience

Customer experience refers to customers’ subjective, spontaneous, and multidimensional responses and reactions that emerge in interactions with experience partners throughout a customer journey (Becker & Jaakkola, 2020; De Keyser et al., 2020; Gahler et al., 2023). Considering that experiences are spontaneous reactions (Becker & Jaakkola, 2020) that emerge as responses to specific interactions, sequences of discrete experiences emerge throughout a customer journey (Gahler et al., 2023).

The customer journey is commonly defined as the process customers

undergo before, during, and after a purchase or service encounter, encompassing a series of touchpoints (e.g., Lemon & Verhoef, 2016). Even though the customer journey is considered a cyclical and dynamic process in which previous experiences influence future ones (Becker et al., 2020; Lemon & Verhoef, 2016; Siebert et al., 2020), analytically, the customer experience literature divides the customer journey into stages (e.g., pre-purchase, purchase, and post-purchase) and, at a more granular level, multiple touchpoints (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016), the points at which the customer interacts directly or indirectly with an organization (Becker & Jaakkola, 2020; Verhoef et al., 2009) within and outside an organization’s control (De Keyser et al., 2020; Lemon & Verhoef, 2016).

While these are useful analytical partitions of the customer journey, they disregard the customer’s perspective. Even though some managerial reports suggest that organizations should divide positive experiences to improve how customers remember their experiences (Bhattacharjee et al., 2016; Chase & Dasu, 2001), they do not explain how these processes occur. The customer experience literature has not addressed the perceptual and cognitive processes through which customers partition journeys into bounded events, or how this affects how they remember their experiences, despite calls for research on these topics (Caruelle et al., 2024; Bitran et al., 2008; LaTour & Carbone, 2014).

Considering this lack of research, we rely on the psychological perspectives of event segmentation (e.g., Newston, 1973; Zacks et al., 2007) and experienced utility (e.g., Kahneman et al., 1993; Redelmeier & Kahneman, 1996) as method theories to build a customer-centric conceptualization of customer journey partitioning and its influence on the remembered experience. Event segmentation is an area of psychology that describes the “perceptual and cognitive processes by which a continuous activity is segmented into meaningful events” (Kurby & Zacks, 2008, p. 72). Individuals make sense of continuous streams of behaviors or activities by organizing information into smaller events (Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Newston, 1973) that later influence the memories of these streams (Gold et al., 2017; Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Zacks & Tversky, 2001).

The second method theory we use is from an area of research known as experienced utility. It has studied how individuals remember their experiences and evaluate them in retrospect (e.g., Kahneman et al., 1993; Redelmeier & Kahneman, 1996), differentiating experienced utility—individuals’ immediate, real-time, lived experiences, frequently expressed in affective states (e.g., pleasure or distress)—from remembered utility—the retrospective evaluation of a sequence of experienced utility (see e.g., Kahneman, 2011). We propose that, just as with experienced and remembered utility, lived and remembered experience are distinct concepts. Lived experience is the customer experience as defined here. The remembered experience is the retrospective account of lived experiences retrieved from memory. Next, we describe how customers partition a customer journey.

3. Customers’ partitioning of the customer journey

Event segmentation is described as a normal, spontaneous part of perception (Gold et al., 2017; Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Zacks et al., 2007) that “controls the allocation of cognitive resources” (Kurby & Zacks, 2008, p. 5). Individuals’ perceptual systems partition continuous processes into events (Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Radvansky & Zacks, 2017; Zacks et al., 2007). An event refers to “a segment of time [...] that is conceived by an observer as having a beginning and an end” (Zacks & Tversky, 2001, p. 17) and that can vary from seconds to tens of minutes (Zacks et al., 2007). Given that, we assume that customers always partition customer journeys into multiple events (Ariely & Zauberman,

2003; LaTour & Carbone, 2014; Montgomery & Unnava, 2009). This is because customers interact with multiple touchpoints that can occur with different service providers and other customers via different channels and at different stages of the customer journey (De Keyser et al., 2020). Even a short journey with a restaurant involves a series of events (e.g., booking a table, arriving at the restaurant, being seated, ordering, etc.).¹ Consistent with event segmentation (Kurby & Zacks, 2008), we present the following definition of customer journey partitioning²:

Premise: Customer journey partitioning refers to the perceptual and cognitive processes through which customers divide a customer journey into events.

Distinctive changes in the stream of behaviors and activities create perceived event boundaries (Magliano et al., 2014; Newston et al., 1977; Zacks et al., 2007; Zacks et al., 2009; Zacks et al., 2009). Event segmentation theory (Zacks et al., 2007) proposes that event segmentation is the result of a process that aims to predict what is going to happen next. Individuals hold event models, that is, working memory representations of “what is happening now” that guide perception. If the incoming information is consistent with an event model, the current event model remains active. However, if the incoming information is inconsistent with the event model (such as for distinctive changes), the event model fails to predict what is happening. The event model then becomes less useful and is therefore updated. The update of an event model is experienced as an event boundary (Magliano et al., 2014; Zacks et al., 2007; Zacks et al., 2009a; Zacks et al., 2009b). Because it is more difficult to predict when distinctive changes occur, distinctive changes tend to create event boundaries (Zacks et al., 2007; Zacks et al., 2009; Zacks et al., 2009).

Distinctive changes range from conceptual changes in goals and actions to physical changes (Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Zacks et al., 2009). Distinctive changes do not need to be surprising and unpredictable; they simply need to indicate that something has ended and that something new is happening. In the context of customer journeys, these changes might refer to changes of service environments (e.g., the customer moving inside the aircraft), changes in interactions with service employees (e.g., service personnel starting a conversation with the customer), service failures that interrupt a current event (e.g., the entertainment system suddenly stops working), changes in other customers' behavior that interrupt a current event (e.g., another passenger starts chatting with the customer), and changes in the customer's own goals (e.g., the passenger decides to go to the bathroom; e.g., Speer et al., 2007; Zwaan et al., 1995). Note that this is not an exhaustive list of distinctive changes that can happen in a customer journey, because all distinctive changes that cannot be predicted with a current event model are likely to trigger event boundaries. However, the more distinctive changes that occur, the more likely individuals are to perceive an event boundary (Magliano et al., 2014; Zacks et al., 2009a). Hence, we propose the following:

P1: Customers perceive event boundaries when they encounter distinctive changes in a customer journey.

Individuals segment events “on a range of temporal grains” or timescales (Kurby & Zacks, 2008, p. 72), from large-grained events (e.g., boarding) to fine-grained events (e.g., scanning one's boarding pass at

the gate, entering the aircraft, finding one's seat; Kurby & Zacks, 2008). Consistent with hierarchical conceptualizations of the customer journey (e.g., Becker et al., 2020; Patrício et al., 2008), event segmentation happens simultaneously at different timescales (Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Zacks et al., 2007; Zacks et al., 2009a). At a higher level, customers can partition the customer journey into large-grained events containing multiple touchpoints. For example, customers might partition their journeys with an airline into the traditional stages of the customer journey: before flight, flight, and after flight. However, considering that touchpoints can differ in nature, control, and purpose (e.g., De Keyser et al., 2020; Patrício et al., 2008), it is likely that customers will also partition events between and within touchpoints. For example, at the touchpoint of boarding, customers might perceive granular event boundaries and, therefore, partition this touchpoint into the subevents of waiting in line, moving in line, scanning the ticket, and so on. Therefore, we propose the following:

P2: Customers partition events across, between, and within touchpoints throughout the customer journey.

4. The influence of customer journey partitioning on the remembered experience

To understand how customer journey partitioning influences how customers remember their experiences, we first need to understand how events and event boundaries are encoded in memory. Event boundaries experienced during the customer journey are used to structure long-term memory encoding (Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Radvansky & Zacks, 2017; Zacks et al., 2007; Zacks & Tversky, 2001). Instead of remembering a continuous stream of behaviors and activities, individuals store events in their long-term memory (Jeunehomme & D'Argembeau, 2020; Kurby & Zacks, 2008). This happens because whenever individuals experience an event boundary, the previous event is perceived to end, drops out of customers' working memory, and is thus encoded as a bounded event (e.g., when entering security control, flight information acquired during check-in is replaced in working memory by knowledge of prohibited items and scanning procedures; Kurby & Zacks, 2008; Zacks et al., 2007). Furthermore, at these points, more extensive processing occurs, which results in a better memory of event boundaries (Gold et al., 2017; Newston & Engquist, 1976; Zacks et al., 2007).

However, we want to understand how customer journey partitioning influences the way customers remember *customer experiences* in their journeys (i.e., the responses and reactions to offering-related stimuli that emerge within and across events). Experienced utility literature has investigated how individuals integrate the sequences of lived experiences into remembered experiences. This research posits that individuals use integration rules, that is, they rely on certain aspects when integrating the sequence of lived experiences into a remembered experience (Caruelle et al., 2024; Kahneman et al., 1993). More interestingly, individuals use different integration rules within and across events (Ariely & Zauberman, 2000; 2003).

When individuals remember their experiences *within* events, they tend to rely on three defining features of the sequence of experiences: peaks, ends, and trends (Montgomery & Unnava, 2009). Peaks—the moment(s) of highest intensity (Caruelle et al., 2024; Kahneman et al., 1993; Redelmeier & Kahneman, 1996)—and ends of lived experiences strongly influence the remembered experience (e.g., Fredrickson & Kahneman, 1993; Kahneman et al., 1993; Redelmeier & Kahneman, 1996). Trends in lived experiences influence remembered experiences such that experiences that improve over time are remembered more positively (e.g., Baumgartner et al., 1997; Hansen & Danaher, 1999). It follows that, depending on the sequence of lived experiences within an event, customers might encode their experiences in memory more positively or negatively than they were lived. For example, if a customer perceives an interaction with a service employee as an event, the peaks, ends, and trends of lived experiences as responses to the interaction influence how the customer encodes that experience in memory.

¹ Although many customer experience researchers consider customer journeys to be dynamic and cyclical without a clear beginning and end (e.g., Lemon & Verhoef, 2016), event segmentation theory suggests that customers perceive a service cycle ending and another beginning, lending relevance to the understanding of customer journey partitioning.

² According to Ulaga et al., (2021, p. 398), premises refer to “statements identifying and defining concepts as the core elements of a theoretical perspective or the delineation of a phenomenon,” while propositions specify and elaborate on relationships between concepts. For this reason, we present this definition as a premise and the rest of our argumentation in propositions.

When expanding research on experienced utility to extended processes that can be segmented into multiple events, studies have found that individuals tend to rely more on the average of experiences across events than on peaks, ends, and trends of the extended process when remembering their experiences (e.g., Ariely & Zauberman, 2000; 2003; Chark et al., 2022; Kemp et al., 2008; Miron-Shatz, 2009; Strijbosch et al., 2019; Strijbosch et al., 2021). For example, Kemp et al. (2008) found that, for a 2- to 16-day vacation, the average of all 24-hour periods was the best predictor of recalled happiness both immediately after the vacation and about one month later. Similarly, Chark et al. (2022) found that for traveling, the simple average of episodic evaluations presented the highest correlation with summary evaluations. This implies that for a long sequence of experiences, such as one that emerges in a customer journey, the *average* of experiences across events in the customer journey is the best predictor of how customers will remember their experiences. For example, when remembering their customer experience with the airline, the customer uses an integration rule by which they tend to average their experiences across events to form the remembered experience of that journey.

Naturally, customers might regard some interactions, touchpoints, or events on their journey as more important than others; these are known as moments of truth. Such moments of truth significantly influence the customer experience (Holmlund et al., 2020). Consistent with our conceptualization, we argue that the stronger influence of moments of truth in the remembered experience occurs because of the *intensity* of the lived experiences during these events and not because the customer attributes greater weight to a particular moment, as patterns within events predict remembered experiences (Ariely & Zauberman, 2003; Strijbosch et al., 2021). In other words, we assume that when a customer regards one event as more important than another (i.e., a moment of truth), their customer experience in that moment will be more intense (e.g., a service failure in a moment of truth is experienced more intensely than a service failure in a touchpoint that is not as important). For example, if a passenger is terrified of flying, turbulence might be regarded as a moment of truth. The customer will have more intense negative experiences during the turbulence. Because of this, the negative experiences emerging from this event will strongly influence the average of the lived experiences and thus their remembered experience, given that the turbulence event was encoded with an intense negative experience. Hence, we propose the following:

P3: Customer journey partitioning influences the remembered experience of the customer journey.

P3a: Customers rely on peaks, ends, and trends of lived experiences to form the remembered experience of an event.

P3b: Customers rely on the average of remembered experiences of events to form the remembered experience of the customer journey.

5. Using customer journey partitioning to design the customer journey

Customer journey design—related to the sequence, consistency, and connectivity of touchpoints across the customer journey (Homburg et al., 2017; Kuehn et al., 2019; Zomerdijs & Voss, 2010)—is considered extremely important in marketing (Gopaldas & Siebert, 2022). The above propositions provide insights into how to design the customer journey such that it positively influences the remembered experience. In this section, we propose that organizations can design *distinctive changes* to trigger event boundaries at desirable points, as well as design the *stimuli* within events to trigger an intended sequence of lived experiences, both of which can influence the remembered experience. Moreover, beyond these general guidelines, we identify boundary conditions around this conceptualization to provide specific guidelines for different types of organizations.

5.1. Designing distinctive changes: How and when?

The above propositions suggest that it can be beneficial for organizations to influence customer journey partitioning. In other words, interruptions can actually be desirable in a customer journey, thereby providing nuance to current assumptions in the literature that emphasize smooth and seamless customer journeys as the ideal (e.g., Jaakkola & Terho, 2021; Ostrom et al., 2021).

But how to create event boundaries if they are a product of customers' perception? Because individuals tend to perceive event boundaries when distinctive changes occur (Newston et al., 1977; Zacks et al., 2007), organizations can seek to design different types of distinctive changes at desired points in the customer journey. The more distinctive changes at a certain point, the more likely customers will be to perceive an event boundary (Magliano et al., 2014; Zacks et al., 2009a). Therefore, practitioners should strive to create multidimensional, distinctive changes in the customer journey, for example, by combining changes in the service environment with employees' behaviors. Airlines, for instance, often stage spatial boundaries (e.g., boarding the aircraft) through ambient cues (e.g., lighting, background music, and welcome drink) and personal interactions (e.g., welcoming passengers, guiding them to their seats, and assisting with hand luggage).

Knowing that organizations can influence customer journey partitioning leads to the question of when event boundaries are desirable. Following the above propositions, we argue that organizations should strive to create event boundaries after intense, positive peak moments of the lived experience (Bhattacharjee et al., 2016; Chase & Dasu, 2001). Customers will encode experiences within events that end positively as highly positive, which will indirectly affect the average of the entire sequence of lived experiences. Conversely, if a customer journey is partitioned immediately following a negative experience, the event is encoded as more negative than lived (e.g., Baumgartner et al., 1997; Fredrickson & Kahneman, 1993; Redelmeier & Kahneman, 1996). Moreover, due to higher processing efforts, individuals remember event boundaries better (Gold et al., 2017; Newston & Engquist, 1976; Zacks et al., 2007).³ Given this, we propose the following:

P4: Organizations can influence the remembered experience by designing distinctive changes in the customer journey.

P4a: Organizations should design distinctive changes after intense positive peaks in the customer journey.

5.2. Designing stimuli within events

Beyond influencing customer journey partitioning, organizations can design stimuli to trigger an intended sequence of experiences within events. While organizations cannot manage customer experiences directly, they can design and manage stimuli within organization-controlled touchpoints to trigger intended experiences (Becker & Jaakkola, 2020). Consistent with earlier research on experienced utility (e.g., Kahneman et al., 1993), practitioners should design stimuli within events (e.g., in-flight meal service) of the customer journey to trigger positive peaks (e.g., a tasty main course, great wine selection), positive endings (e.g., an additional round of ice cream), and a positive trend (e.g., a standard meal service ending with a sweet surprise). Likewise, organizations should do their best to prevent service failures in the final moments of events. Hence, we propose the following:

P5: Organizations can influence the remembered experience by designing

³ An alternative explanation is that customers might adapt to both positive and negative experiences (Nelson & Meyvis, 2008). Customers tend to adapt to experiences in a way that their intensity is attenuated over time. Hence, partitioning positive and negative experiences interrupts this hedonic adaptation (Nelson & Meyvis, 2008). In this view, organizations should partition positive experiences into multiple events as well as combine negative experiences into a single event (Bhattacharjee et al., 2016; Chase & Dasu, 2001).

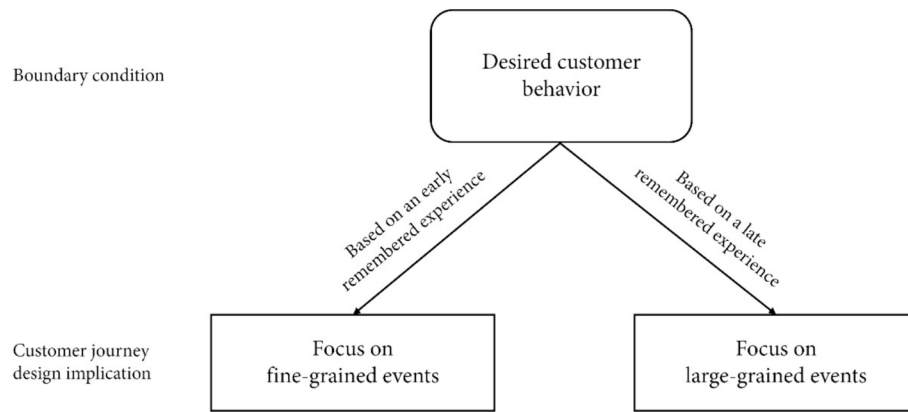


Fig. 1. Desired customer behavior as boundary condition for customer journey design

stimuli within events that trigger intended sequences of customer experiences.

P5a: Organizations should design stimuli to trigger intense positive peaks, ends, and trends within events.

5.3. Boundary conditions for utilizing customer journey partitioning in customer journey design

We identify two boundary conditions that influence how organizations can utilize customer journey partitioning to design the customer journey in a way that positively influences the remembered experience: the desired customer behavior outcomes of the journey and the nature of the customer journey.

5.3.1. Customer behavior outcomes: Early vs. late remembered experiences

Should organizations focus on designing fine-grained events within touchpoints or large-grained events between and across touchpoints? Katsikeas et al. (2016) argued for a marketing-performance outcome chain in which marketing interventions (such as customer journey design) influence customers' mindsets (such as the remembered experience), which in turn influence customer behavior outcomes (e.g., retention, word-of-mouth, or reviews). Following this chain, we argue that decisions related to customer journey design depend on the desired customer behavior outcomes of the customer journey that can be maximized by focusing on an early or a late remembered experience.

The desired customer behavior outcomes—customers behaviors, attitudes, and decisions—rely on the remembered experience at a certain point in time (e.g., Koenig-Lewis & Palmer, 2008; Wirtz et al., 2003). For example, some customer behavior outcomes—such as customer reviews, online word-of-mouth, and immediate contract renewal—rely on a remembered experience immediately after the customer has undergone that particular journey (i.e., an early remembered experience). Conversely, other customer behavior outcomes—such as customer return (within weeks or months), contract renewal after a long period without interactions, or repurchase behaviors—rely on a remembered experience weeks or months after undergoing a customer journey (i.e., a late remembered experience).

The design decision of whether to design fine- vs. large-grained events depends on whether one wants to primarily optimize the early vs. the late remembered experience. This happens because the time interval between the journey and its retrieval influences the remembered experience (Geng et al., 2013; Huber et al., 1997; Montgomery & Unnava, 2009). The closer the time interval between the customer journey and the remembered experience, the more the peaks, ends, and trends within fine-grained events of lived experiences matter for the remembered experience (Huber et al., 1997). Conversely, the greater the time interval between the customer journey and the remembered experience (i.e., the more time that has passed between the customer journey and the time of retrieval), the less customers remember fine-grained events (Huber et al., 1997).

Geng et al. (2013) found that immediately after lived experiences (the next day), individuals rely on episodic memory (i.e., memory related to specific episodes or events, which can decay fast). However, after a while (3–7 weeks), when individuals cannot remember specific events anymore, there is a shift to semantic memory, which consists of generalizations regarding these events (e.g., “people feel happy when they celebrate their birthday, so I must have felt happy at my birthday;” Geng et al., 2013). In this case, similar events are aggregated and defining features become less salient for the formation of the remembered experience (Huber et al., 1997). Consequently, if events are mixed up with one another, the ending of a specific event will likely shift to the middle of a larger sequence of events (Huber et al., 1997; Montgomery & Unnava, 2009).

More specifically, Huber et al. (1997) hypothesized that a higher temporal distance between a sequence of events and their retrieval triggers a broader temporal grain when remembering the experiences. Therefore, on occasions of retrieval shortly after the customer journey (e.g., immediately to 1–2 days after), customers will remember specific fine-grained events and the sequence of experiences within these events (Huber et al., 1997). However, as time passes (e.g., a few weeks to months), events start grouping together in memory into large-grained events (Huber et al., 1997; see also Zacks et al., 2007), and specific peaks, ends, and trends within these fine-grained events become less important.

Hence, organizations that seek to establish immediate customer behavior outcomes—such as customer reviews, online word-of-mouth, or direct contract renewal—should seek to primarily optimize an early remembered experience by designing stimuli within small, fine-grained events within and between touchpoints in the customer journey, as these stimuli will largely influence how customers remember their journeys and influence these outcomes. For example, for vacation rental hosts, the review left a few days after the journey is extremely important; therefore, such hosts should design stimuli to trigger peak experiences in multiple fine-grained events (e.g., offering a high-quality sleep experience, providing multiple options for breakfast, and assisting with transportation arrangements at checkout).

Conversely, organizations that seek to establish distant customer behavior outcomes—such as customer return (within weeks or months), contract renewal after a long period without interactions, or repurchase behaviors—should seek to primarily optimize a late remembered experience by designing stimuli to trigger intended sequences within larger-grained events (e.g., across touchpoints). For example, a department store that wants loyal customers to return every few weeks or months should pay attention to the design of stimuli within large events (e.g., a store visit as a single event) to trigger intended sequences of experiences. Hence, we propose the following:

P6: Organizations should consider the desired customer behavior outcomes and whether they are based on an early or late remembered experience in customer journey design.

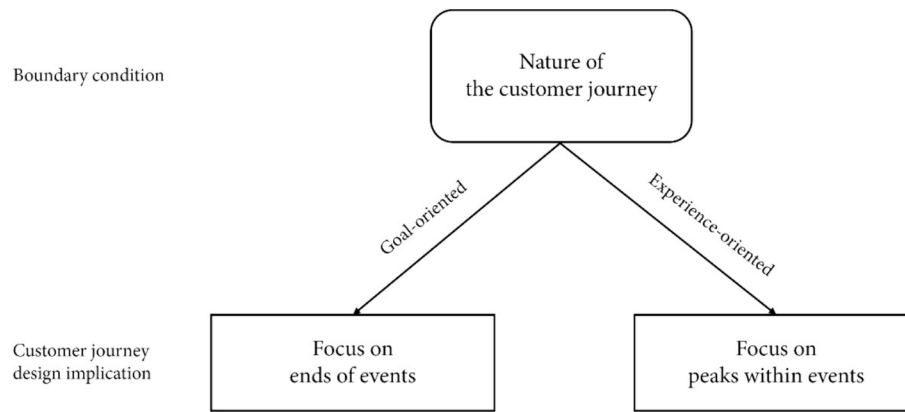


Fig. 2. Nature of the customer journey as a boundary condition for customer journey design

P6a: The closer (vs. farther) the distance between the journey and the remembered experience, the more important the design of stimuli within fine-grained (vs. large-grained) events is for the formation of the remembered experience.

Fig. 1 illustrates the design implications of this boundary condition: Depending on the desired outcome of the experience, organizations can seek to optimize an early or late remembered experience, which in turn has implications for whether they will predominantly focus on fine- or large-grained events in the customer journey.⁴

5.3.2. Nature of the customer journey: Goal- vs. experience-oriented

Goal-oriented customer journeys are those that predominantly derive meaning from the outcome (Ariely & Carmon, 2003). In other words, customers typically seek these journeys to achieve an end-goal, such as those of banks, mechanics, car washes, or IT services. Experience-oriented customer journeys are those that predominantly derive their meaning from the customer journey itself (Ariely & Carmon, 2003; Zomerdijsk & Voss, 2010). In other words, customers seek these journeys for the experiences over the duration of the journey, such as those of amusement parks, cruises, or massage services.⁵

For goal-oriented customer journeys, the endings of events should more significantly influence the remembered experience because the ending represents the service outcome (Carmon & Kahneman, 1996; Fredrickson, 2000; Tully & Meyvis, 2016). Therefore, we argue that goal-oriented customer journeys should focus on triggering intense, positive customer experiences at the end of events. Because goals can be sub-divided into smaller, lower-order goals (Becker et al., 2020; Powers, 1973), each event in the customer journey represents a goal-oriented step or a milestone (Gopaldas & Siebert, 2022).

Conversely, experience-oriented customer journeys derive their meaning from the process itself (Ariely & Carmon, 2003). Scholars suggest that a sequence that starts with low-intensity experiences, increases, reaches a climax, and then gradually decreases (i.e., an arc-like or inverted-U sequence) is preferred for experience-oriented, hedonic offerings (Hirschmann & Holbrook, 1982; Lim & Kim, 2018; Zomerdijsk & Voss, 2010). Experience-oriented services commonly design multiple

peaks throughout their customer journeys (Zomerdijsk & Voss, 2010). This makes sense considering that peaks within events were found to be the most significant predictors of the overall evaluation of an experience-oriented service (Strijbosch et al., 2021). Moreover, recent studies also suggest that experience-oriented journeys can benefit from multiple peaks in the form of varied moments of delight and thrills (Gopaldas & Siebert, 2022), experiential roller coaster (Siebert et al., 2020), or sentiment volatility (Chark et al., 2022). Hence, we propose the following:

P6: Organizations should consider the nature of the customer journey in customer journey design.

P7a: For goal-oriented customer journeys, practitioners should design stimuli to trigger positive endings within events.

P7b: For experience-oriented customer journeys, practitioners should design stimuli to trigger positive peak(s) within events.

Fig. 2 illustrates the design implications of this boundary condition. Depending on the nature of the customer journey, organizations can seek to prioritize the design of stimuli to trigger high peaks or ends within events.

Table 1 presents more refined suggestions for how organizations can design the customer journey to positively influence the remembered experience considering these boundary conditions.

6. Conclusion

6.1. Conceptual framework

Fig. 3 presents the conceptual framework of how customer journey partitioning influences the remembered experience. The upper part of the framework shows that customers use distinctive changes within, between, and across touchpoints in their customer journey as the basis for customer journey partitioning, thus answering RQ1. In other words, when encountering distinctive changes throughout the customer journey, customers divide them into discrete, hierarchically organized events.

The center part of the framework represents the interaction between the sequence of lived experiences and the perception of event boundaries within the customer journey influencing the remembered experience, thus answering RQ2. Within events in the customer journey, the peaks, ends, and trends of lived experiences influence how the experiences within those events are encoded in memory. However, when considering the entire customer journey, customers average their experiences across events.

The lower part of the framework shows how organizations can use customer journey partitioning to design the customer journey in a way that positively influences the remembered experience. This can be done by (a) designing distinctive changes in the customer journey to trigger event boundaries and (b) designing stimuli within events to trigger the

⁴ We assume that an organization might have a predominant desired outcome. However, it might be that organizations have multiple equally desirable outcomes that require maximization of both early and late remembered experiences. In such cases, organizations can simultaneously focus on fine- and large-grained events by focusing on a hierarchical visualization of events in the customer journey.

⁵ The key aspect of differentiation here is the reason why customers seek these types of journeys: to achieve an end-goal or to live experiences throughout the journey. In this sense, we argue that journeys can fall within a continuum in which they are predominantly goal- or experience-oriented depending on what customers seek from them.

Table 1
Customer Journey Design Considering the Customer Behavior Outcomes and the Nature of the Customer Journey.

		Nature of the customer journey	
		Goal-oriented	Experience-oriented
Examples of journeys		• Ride-sharing services • Fitness apps • MBA courses • Wedding planning services • Funeral services	• Vacation rentals • Museums • Dance classes • Massage • Fine-dining restaurants
Desired customer behavior outcome	Based on an early remembered experience (e.g., customer reviews)	• Focus on designing stimuli to trigger intense positive ends in fine-grained events • Focus on designing stimuli to smooth over negative experiences at the end of fine-grained events • Focus on designing distinctive changes after intense positive experiences • Illustration: Consultancy services can end every meeting with a positive and upbeat review of the goals achieved/advanced. When a particularly positive experience occurs, the consultancy can design distinctive changes in the journey (e.g., by celebrating a milestone). These design measures will optimize the early remembered experience, which is critical when seeking to begin another contract immediately after one has ended.	• Focus on designing stimuli to trigger intense positive peaks in fine-grained events • Focus on designing stimuli to avoid flat experiences within fine-grained events • Focus on designing distinctive changes after “inverted U”-shaped experiences • Illustration: Nightclubs can provide a smooth entrance experience, offer daily specials, and ask their bands or DJs to develop several concert sections (i.e., sets) with high peaks (e.g., engaging crowd participation with sing-alongs and inviting audience members on stage). These design measures will likely enhance the perception of distinctive changes, ensure positive peaks in each event, and, thus, optimize the early remembered experience (which is important to make customers return in the next few days).
	Based on a late remembered experience (e.g., customer return)	• Focus on designing stimuli to trigger intense positive ends in large events • Focus on designing stimuli to smooth over negative experiences at the ends of large events • Focus on designing distinctive changes after intense positive experiences • Illustration: Consultancy services can break down a project in large stages, focusing on designing stimuli to end these stages on a high note (e.g., review of goals achieved after each large stage). In case of a negative experience at the end of these stages, customers should be immediately reassured, and the failure recovered, if possible, with attempts to smooth over the negative experience.	• Focus on designing stimuli to trigger intense positive peaks in large events • Focus on designing stimuli to avoid flat experiences within large events • Focus on designing distinctive changes after “inverted U”-shaped experiences • Illustration: When optimizing the late remembered experience, nightclubs should design stimuli that trigger peaks within large events throughout the customer journey. They could focus on asking each band or DJ to provide one surprising and intense peak (e.g., unexpected cover songs, improvisation, and guest appearances) during their concert.

intended sequence of experiences, thus answering RQ3. The desired customer behavior outcome of the journey and the nature of the customer journey further refine these implications.

6.2. Theoretical contributions

Our conceptualization of customer journey partitioning contributes to the customer experience literature in several ways. First, we propose that customers partition their customer journeys into smaller, bounded events when they encounter distinctive changes within, between, and across touchpoints; our conceptualization thus answers calls for research to understand this process (e.g., Baumgartner et al., 1997; Bitran et al., 2008; LaTour & Carbone, 2014). Although the hierarchical partitioning resembles previous conceptualizations of the customer journey (Becker et al., 2020; Hamilton & Price, 2019), our conceptualization extends the customer experience literature by considering *how customers perceive the partitioning of the journey* as opposed to partitioning into stages and phases from an organization’s perspective (e.g., Lemon & Verhoef, 2016; Voorhees et al., 2017). As seen, this is important considering that customer journey partitioning influences the remembered experience (Zacks & Tversky, 2001), which, in turn, is decisive for customers’ attitudes, intentions, and behaviors (Wirtz et al., 2003).

Second, we propose that customer journey partitioning influences the remembered experience through the interaction between the sequence of lived experiences and the perception of event boundaries in the customer journey. The service and customer experience literature have suggested that focusing on positive peaks, strong ends, and positive trends can influence how customers remember their experiences (e.g., Chase & Dasu, 2001; Hansen & Danaher, 1999; Zomerdijsk & Voss, 2010). However, this literature has not considered that these findings are not readily applicable to experiences that emerge throughout customer journeys, which are naturally perceived as comprising several events. In other words, the customer experience literature has largely

ignored the fact that the “peak-end” rule does not apply to extended processes such as customer journeys. Answering calls to understand how the peak-end rule might change in extended customer journeys (Caruelle et al., 2024), we integrate two distinct method theories—event segmentation and experienced utility—to offer a more suitable proposition of how peaks, ends, and trends in a customer journey influence the remembered experience.

Third, by considering the influence of customer journey partitioning on the remembered experience, we suggest new dimensions of customer journey design for the customer experience literature (e.g., Kuehnl et al., 2019). Beyond the thematic cohesion, consistency, and context sensitivity of touchpoints (Homburg et al., 2017; Kuehnl et al., 2019), our conceptualization suggests that two new dimensions should be considered: (a) the design of distinctive changes in the customer journey and (b) the design of stimuli to trigger an intended sequence of lived experiences. While Zomerdijsk and Voss (2010) considered the orchestration of stimuli and the structure of events to be important for the design of experience-centric services, no study has considered how to combine these two dimensions in customer journey design to positively influence the remembered experience.

Fourth, these two dimensions challenge some assumptions in the customer experience literature. By considering the design of distinctive changes in the customer journey, we provide nuance to the current assumptions that emphasize smooth and seamless customer journeys as the ideal (e.g., Jaakkola & Terho, 2021; Kuehnl et al., 2019; Ostrom et al., 2021). Our conceptualization proposes that interruptions that mark event boundaries in a customer journey can be desirable, depending on when they happen, particularly after the most positive moments of an experience (Bhattacharjee et al., 2016; Chase & Dasu, 2001). This adds to recent studies showing how disjointed journeys can also lead to positive customer experiences in certain contexts (Gasparin et al., 2022; Siebert et al., 2020). Considering the design of stimuli to trigger an intended sequence of lived experiences also challenges the

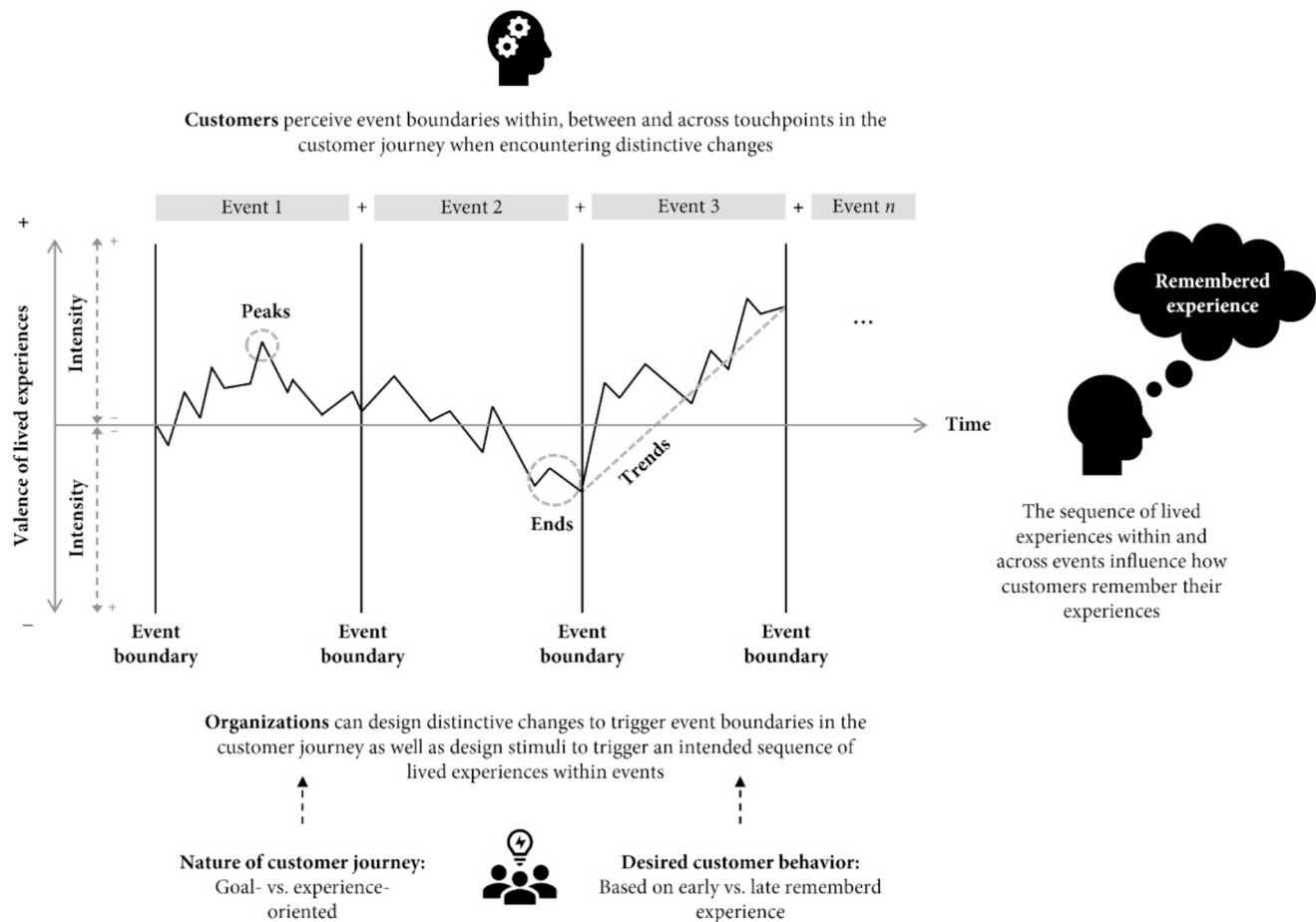


Fig. 3. Conceptual framework: Customer journey partitioning and its influence on the remembered experience

assumption that firms should always strive to provide highly positive customer experiences (e.g., Becker & Jaakkola, 2020; Pine & Gilmore, 1998). A sequence of lived experiences with mildly positive or neutral experiences at the beginning of an event that improves to a peak will likely be remembered more positively than an experience that is flat and positive throughout the event.

Fifth, we propose two boundary conditions that influence how organizations can utilize customer journey partitioning to positively influence the remembered experience: the desired customer behavior outcome of the journey and the nature of the customer journey (goal- vs. experience-oriented). The identification of these boundary conditions leads to nuanced recommendations on how to design the customer journey to positively influence the remembered experience.

6.3. Practical implications

Based on our conceptualization, we provide step-by-step recommendations to practitioners regarding three areas: (1) journey strategy, (2) journey understanding, and (3) journey design.

6.3.1. Journey strategy

Katsikeas et al. (2016) proposed a marketing-performance outcome chain in which marketing interventions (such as customer journey design) influence customers' mindsets (such as the remembered experience), which in turn impact customer behaviors (e.g., retention, word-of-mouth, reviews) and drive product-, market-, and financial-performance outcomes (i.e., key KPIs). It follows then that utilizing our findings in customer journey design can indirectly influence an organization's KPIs through customers' remembered experiences.

When considering the journey strategy, organizations can ask themselves: What are the customer behavior outcomes that most likely lead to achieving the organization's KPIs? As these customer behaviors depend on the remembered experience (e.g., Koenig-Lewis & Palmer, 2008; Wirtz et al., 2003), this has important implications for customer journey design. This is because certain target customer behaviors occur immediately after the journey (e.g., customer reviews) while others happen weeks or months after a journey has ended (e.g., customer return). Deciding on these target customer behaviors thus comes with implications for optimizing the early or/and late remembered experience, which, in turn, has implications for the understanding and design of fine- or/and large-grained events in the customer journey.

6.3.2. Journey understanding

Customer journey mapping is an important tool for understanding how customers experience customer journeys. The literature offers several guidelines on how to map customer journeys (e.g., Rosenbaum et al., 2017), and common to those are depicting stages of the customer journey, touchpoints (and stimuli that customers perceive), and experiences in these touchpoints. Our conceptualization highlights the importance of understanding the following three specific aspects of the journey: (a) the nature of the customer journey, (b) events from the customer's perspective, and (c) sequences of lived experiences.

First, organizations should understand whether customers predominantly seek their journeys to achieve end-goals or to live experiences over the duration of the journeys. Therefore, organizations should include customers' goals and experience expectations in their customer journey maps and consider the role of engaging with specific customer journeys in customers' lives (e.g., Becker et al., 2020; Bettencourt et al.,

2022; Hamilton & Price, 2019).

Second, it is important to map events from the customer's perspective. More specifically, following the strategic decision mentioned in the previous section, organizations should map fine-grained events when seeking to optimize the early remembered experience and large-grained events when seeking to optimize the late remembered experience. Customer journey maps often depict partitions of the customer journey into stages and touchpoints (i.e., from the organization's perspective). Instead, practitioners could map the events as perceived by customers to design stimuli that trigger the intended sequence of experiences in these events.

Event boundaries can be detected by simply asking customers (Kurby & Zacks, 2008). Event segmentation literature, for example, has used experimental designs that ask participants to watch a video of a journey they underwent (e.g., Jeunehomme & D'Argembeau, 2020) and to press the space bar whenever they perceive a segment to begin or end (e.g., Gold et al., 2017; Magliano et al., 2014). We argue that practitioners could apply similar procedures by showing customers videos of typical journeys and asking them to indicate event boundaries. Because individuals tend to agree on event boundaries (Newston, 1973; Newston et al., 1977), such tasks could be very informative and integrated within customer journey mapping workshops. Retrospective approaches might also be useful for understanding event boundaries in the customer journey. For example, post-experience questionnaires (e.g., Reitsamer et al., 2020), semi-structured interviews (e.g., Strijbosch et al., 2021), or event-based approaches (e.g., Åkesson et al., 2014) asking customers to talk about or visualize their customer journeys might be helpful in identifying event boundaries. However, they might be limited in understanding customers' lived experiences.

Third, it is important to understand the sequence of lived experiences within events. Traditional customer journey maps often depict simple,

unidimensional, remembered experiences throughout the journey. Practitioners could be more detailed in mapping the sequence of lived experiences and their evolution over time within and across events. By understanding the sequence of lived experiences throughout the customer journey, practitioners will be better informed on when to design distinctive changes in the customer journey.

Examples of tools and methods to capture lived experiences include real-time experience tracking, in which customers report on touchpoints through text messages (Baxendale et al., 2015), neurophysiological and electrophysiological methods (Verhulst et al., 2020), continuously moving a slider on an emotion or discomfort meter (e.g., Fredrickson & Kahneman, 1993; Kahneman et al., 1993), diaries (e.g., Becker et al., 2020), mobile ethnography (e.g., Muskat et al., 2013), and the Day Reconstruction Method (Chark et al., 2022).

6.3.3. Journey design

The journey can be designed within and across fine- and large-grained events. Within events, organizations can design stimuli to trigger an intended sequence of experiences. Although the literature has identified several stimuli that influence the customer experience (e.g., social environment, service interface, and assortment) (Verhoef et al., 2009), customers respond to a holistic combination of stimuli (Zomer-dijk & Voss, 2010). Therefore, organizations should identify the combination of stimuli most likely to trigger positive and intense customer experiences and employ these stimuli at specific points within events, so they trigger the desired sequence of experiences. More specifically, organizations should design combinations of stimuli that trigger high endings of events for goal-oriented journeys and combinations of stimuli that trigger high peaks within events for experience-oriented journeys. For example, for work travel, a journey with an airline would likely be goal-oriented. Therefore, this airline should end events— such as

Table 2
Managerial Implications Across Multiple Contexts⁷.

Scenario	Issue	Management Implications
1. James Crawford, a senior lecturer at Pacific Tech University, holds lectures up to three hours, with small breaks in between. He is thinking about how he can organize the breaks differently to improve his students feedback and scores.	When should James insert breaks to improve student feedback? Should James plan one peak in each lecture or several smaller peaks throughout the lectures?	- James' goal of improving student feedback requires an optimization of the early remembered experience (Journey strategy; P6) - This implies that James should focus on scripting fine-grained events within lectures (Journey design; P6) - Within these fine-grained events, James should focus on ending them on high notes, as going to college is predominantly goal-oriented (Journey design; P5; P7) - Moreover, James should avoid inserting breaks when the students appear tired; rather, James should insert breaks when the class is highly engaged (Journey design; P4; P7)
2. Funky Town, a nightclub in London, hired a local, relatively unknown cover band who insists on playing their new songs which are not known by the nightclub's clients.	When should the band play the songs that are unknown to the audience?	Considering that positive trends result in better remembered experiences and assuming that an unknown song would be a more negative experience than listening to popular songs, the band should include their original songs in the beginning of their sets (Journey design; P5)
3. In the next week, Funky Town hired the same band, but agreed that they would bring a famous guest to sing three songs. The band insists on bringing the guest for the second song, but John, Funky Town's manager, is skeptical.	At what point in the concert should they bring in the guest?	- In the middle or the end of the concert are both good options, as peaks and ends positively influence the remembered experience (Journey design; P4) - However, considering that clients go to nightclubs for the experience, peaks are favored in this situation (Journey design; P7)
4. Apex Advisors, a consultancy agency, wants to increase the proportion of customers who renew contracts immediately after their old one ends. In order to know how they are doing, they plan to map the customer journey. However, they are unsure regarding the level of granularity.	Should Apex map fine- or large-grained events in this customer journey?	- Apex's goal of immediate contract renewal requires an optimization of the early remembered experience (Journey strategy; P6) - It follows then that they should create a more granular customer journey map seeking to identify fine-grained events, particularly toward the end of the journeys. Apex could zoom-in and do customer journey maps for specific key events in the journey (Journey understanding; P6)
5. Silva & Silva, a grocery chain, would like to map their in-store shopping experience. Maria, the customer experience manager, is deciding what aspects should be captured and which tools are required beyond the customer's steps.	How should data be collected and which tools should be utilized to build the customer journey map?	As the sequence of lived experiences influences the remembered experience, Maria and her team could apply neurophysiological tools (e.g., galvanic skin-response or facial expression recognition) to capture customers' experience during their store visit (Journey understanding; P5)

⁷ The table was inspired by Sivakumar et al. (2014).

Table 3
Customer Journey Design Checklist for Practitioners.

	Steps	Considerations
JOURNEY STRATEGY	1. Define customer behavior outcomes	■ What customer behavior outcomes are more likely to lead to achieving the organization's KPIs?
	2. Define the target experience ⁶	■ What kind of affective, cognitive, sensorial, behavioral, and/or social experiences can lead to these customer behavior outcomes?
JOURNEY UNDERSTANDING	3. Map the customer journey	■ What target experience matches the organization's strategy and brand image? ■ Is the journey predominantly goal- or experience-oriented? ■ What are the key stages, touchpoints, events, stimuli, and lived experiences from the customer's perspective? ■ Map the sequence of lived experiences: focus on fine- or large-grained events? ⇒ If the customer behavior outcomes rely on an early (vs. late) remembered experience, map fine-grained (vs. large-grained) events.
	4. Design combinations of stimuli to trigger intended sequences of lived experiences within events	■ Is the journey predominantly goal- or experience-oriented? ⇒ If the journey is predominantly goal-oriented (vs. experience-oriented), design stimuli for strong endings (vs. high peaks) within events. ■ Should the stimuli be designed within fine- or large-grained events? ⇒ If the customer behavior outcomes rely on the early (vs. late) remembered experience, design fine-grained (vs. large-grained) events.
JOURNEY DESIGN	5. Design distinctive changes at desired points in the customer journey	■ When to design distinctive changes? ⇒ If the journey is predominantly goal-oriented (vs. experience-oriented), design distinctive changes after high peaks (vs. inverted-U-shaped experiences).
	6. Design seamless transitions between events and touchpoints ⁷	■ Which paths can customers take in the journey? ■ How can the transition between touchpoints be facilitated?
	7. Decide on the level of consistency across touchpoints and channels ⁸	■ What is the theme across touchpoints? ■ Are the touchpoints across channels integrated and consistent? ■ Are there justifiable differences across channels (e.g., in pricing) from the customer's perspective?
	8. Personalize touchpoints ⁹	■ How to dissociate from negative outsourced touchpoints? ■ How can touchpoints be customized with individual needs? ■ How can customization and privacy trade-offs be balanced?

⁶A target experience refers to “a shared idea of an intended customer experience that is used by a provider firm to drive CX facilitation and serves as a link between the firm's strategy for competing through CX and its CX management efforts” (Panina, 2022, p. 136).

⁷Jaakkola and Terho (2021).

⁸Gasparin et al. (2022); Kranzbühler et al. (2019); Kuehnl et al. (2019).

⁹Kuehnl et al. (2019).

“booking” or “flying”—on a high note (e.g., the captain bidding travelers goodbye when they exit the aircraft). Similarly, it is crucial to smooth over negative episodes that may occur at the end of these events (e.g., technical failure in the app or turbulence while landing) by providing immediate information and recovery efforts so as not to risk ending these events on a mediocre or low note.

Across events, organizations can design distinctive changes in desired points in the customer journey to create perceptions of event boundaries. For goal-oriented journeys, organizations should seek to insert interruptions at high points of the lived experience. For experience-oriented journeys, organizations should seek to insert interruptions after inverted U-shaped experiences. For example, a college professor can insert breaks in their sessions when students are highly engaged (vs. traditionally taking a break when students begin feeling tired). In this manner, students will remember events in the lecture more positively than lived, which can have implications for their continued efforts toward learning in the future (Finn, 2010).

For designing stimuli and distinctive changes in the customer journey, organizations can employ different service tools. For instance, the service script specifies the actions service employees should take in service interactions and can be used to “facilitate control over service events” (Harris et al., 2003, p. 186). Airlines, for example, could serve their first-class meals in three courses, thus influencing whether customers perceive the three courses as three distinct events (i.e., partitioning the positive experiences). However, as not everything can be scripted, other tools—such as empowerment and training of frontline employees (Zhang & Geng, 2019)—might be needed, for example, to prevent events from ending on a negative note. For negative experiences, employees could be trained and empowered to assure customers that they will recover service failures immediately when they happen so that customers perceive a slight increase in their experience trend as part of a single event. Table 2 illustrates the applications of the principles

underlying our propositions. Table 3 presents a customer journey design checklist for practitioners, complemented with other relevant sources.

6.4. Limitations and suggestions for future research

Our conceptualization should be seen in light of certain limitations. First, this is a conceptual paper with the aim of developing theory (vs. testing theory). We suggest developing hypotheses from our conceptual framework to empirically test them. This would likely require innovative methods of research that can capture both lived experiences and event segmentation in real time (e.g., Caruelle et al., 2024; Verhulst et al., 2020).

Second, while we acknowledge that customers can partition customer journeys at multiple levels, it would be interesting to investigate at which level they actually partition with regard to customer journeys. Of note, we suggest that researchers be attentive to how they instruct respondents to partition their journeys, as they can alter the hierarchical level at which individuals segment events (Newston, 1973).

Third, the experienced utility literature shows that averages are often the best but not the only predictor of remembered experiences in extended journeys. Our conceptual framework assumes that customers do not give any greater weight to a particular event but tend to average the events. It would be fruitful to empirically investigate whether customers indeed weigh specific events in a customer journey differently or whether capturing the intensity of experiences already accommodates the possibility that some events and touchpoints are more important than others.

Finally, in this paper, we focus on the sequence of experiences and customer journey partitioning as factors that influence the remembered experience. However, there are other factors that also influence the remembered experience that we did not address here. For example, customers' purpose in retrieving an experience might influence the

remembered experience, as customers frequently use “rosy-colored glasses” when they want to repeat an experience that is difficult to justify (Cowley, 2008). Expectations might also affect how customers remember their experiences. Some studies suggest that surprising, unanticipated, or distinctive experiences might influence the weight of peaks and endings because they are more memorable (e.g., Montgomery & Unnava, 2009). Other potential factors are social context (Bhargave & Montgomery, 2013), information received between the customer journey and the retrieval (Bettman, 1979), and customers’ ability to partition customer journeys (Gold et al., 2017). These factors could be considered as additional boundary conditions of our conceptualization.

To conclude, although the customer experience literature presents some analytical partitions of the customer journey (e.g., pre-purchase, purchase, and post-purchase), customers’ perspectives have been neglected. We draw on psychological perspectives in event segmentation and experienced utility to develop a customer-centric conceptualization of customer journey partitioning and its influence on the remembered experience. We show that customers use distinctive changes as the basis of customer journey partitioning, and that the interaction between the sequence of lived experiences and the perception of event boundaries influences how customers later remember their experiences. Moreover, we provide tailored recommendations for organizations on how to design the customer journey based on these processes. We hope that our conceptualization spurs future research in the field.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Bernd F. Reitsamer: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Project administration, Conceptualization. **Larissa Becker:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Conceptualization.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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